

Read **Text A** and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2** on the question paper.

Text A: The Final Performance

Abdul Hayee has accompanied retired actor Haseeb Piracha to the Crescent Theatre. The building is due to be demolished the following morning.

- 1 By the time Haseeb Piracha and I reached the Crescent Theatre, rain had polished the pavement into black glass. The building leaned over the narrow street, its stone angels stained by soot and its red sign missing three letters. A notice tied to the entrance announced that demolition would begin at nine the following morning. Haseeb read it twice. "Then we are exactly on time," he said, although evening was already closing around us. 5
- 2 I had agreed to help because my mother said an elderly man should not carry boxes alone. Haseeb, however, attacked the theatre steps with the offended dignity of a king returning from exile. At the top he paused, pretending to examine the broken ticket booth while his breathing settled. Across the road, cafes glowed with warmth. The theatre stood apart, blind-windowed and stubborn. I wondered why anyone would enter such a place for one old trunk. 10
- 3 The side door surrendered to Haseeb's key after several attempts. Our torchlight uncovered a kingdom of dust: torn programmes, cracked mirrors and posters whose colours had faded to bruised shadows. The air smelled of damp velvet and cold plaster. Haseeb did not hesitate. He crossed the foyer, ignored the office corridor and pushed through a door marked STAGE. "You still know the way," I He touched the wall. "Some buildings remember for you." 15
- 4 The auditorium opened below us. Hundreds of seats rose in curved rows, their folded cushions resembling dark mouths. On stage, the main curtain hung in heavy red folds, grey with dust. Haseeb descended the aisle slowly, but when his shoes touched the boards, his back straightened. He looked taller. At centre stage he brushed dirt from a brass star set into the floor. Two names were engraved there: Haseeb Piracha and Sameera Piracha. He covered Sameera's name with his shoe. 20
- 5 "The trunk is backstage," I reminded him. Instead, Haseeb crossed to the lighting desk and pressed several switches. Nothing happened. He struck the panel with his palm, then tried again. I joined him, mainly to stop him forcing the brittle controls. For several seconds the largest lever resisted us like a rusted bone. Then it dropped. Somewhere above, cables twitched awake, and a single spotlight spilled onto the stage like a pale coin. 30
- 6 Haseeb stepped into the circle of light. A loose board shifted beneath him and he stumbled. I caught his elbow, but he pulled away with a sharpness that startled us both. "I have stood on this stage for fifty years," he snapped. The empty seats seemed to receive the words and return them more coldly. Then his face softened. "Though not always steadily," he added, producing a smile that could not disguise his embarrassment. 35

- 7 Backstage, we found the trunk beneath collapsed scenery painted to resemble a garden. Its leather straps had split, and one corner had been gnawed by mice. Inside lay costume jewellery, a silver-painted crown and several scripts tied with blue ribbon. Haseeb lifted the thinnest script as though it might bruise beneath his fingers. Its pages were crowded with corrections in green ink. Beside one speech, someone had written: Do not perform sadness; let the silence carry it. A dried jasmine flower rested between the final pages. 40
- 8 Haseeb explained that Sameera had been the theatre's finest actor, although reviewers often described her merely as "Haseeb Piracha's wife". She had rewritten scenes, trained younger performers and rescued productions when directors lost control. Yet the anniversary booklet had printed his photograph across two pages and mentioned her in one sentence. "She said applause disappears as soon as the curtain falls," he told me. "But forgetting is not the same as silence." Sameera had died six years earlier. 45 50
- 9 I had known her only from a photograph in Haseeb's sitting room: a serious woman wearing an enormous crown. In the script, however, I could see her humour in the impatient arrows, her confidence in words underlined twice and her kindness in notes for nervous actors. Haseeb admitted that he had not entered the theatre since her memorial. The trunk was not what he had come to save. He wanted the script because it held the part of Sameera that photographs could not. 55
- 10 Haseeb carried it onto the stage. The spotlight flickered but remained. He stood on the brass star and began the final speech from the play they had performed together. At first his voice sounded papery and uncertain. Then it deepened, travelling into the balcony and filling the torn curtains with life. He spoke to an invisible queen, paused as if listening to her reply, and held out his hand to empty air. For one strange moment, I forgot the leaking roof and broken seats. The theatre seemed crowded. 60
- 11 When the speech ended, no applause followed. Rain tapped the roof, and somewhere backstage water fell into a bucket. Haseeb bowed nevertheless. I found myself clapping, awkwardly at first and then with enough force to wake echoes from every corner. The spotlight failed with a small sigh. In the darkness Haseeb laughed, not like an old man but like the figure smiling from the faded posters. 65
- 12 Before we left, he placed the script inside a dry archive case for the city museum. At the side door, he handed me the theatre key. It felt unexpectedly warm from his palm. "They will need this tomorrow," I said. "Eventually," he replied. I carried it down the steps, and he did not ask for it back. Behind us, the damaged sign caught the headlights of a passing car and blazed briefly above the entrance - not restored, not performing, but still capable of an encore. 70

Read Text A, *The Final Performance*, in the insert and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2**.

Question 1

- (a) From paragraph 1, identify one detail which suggests that the theatre has been neglected.

..... [1]

- (b) **Using your own words**, explain what the text means when it says Haseeb 'attacked the theatre steps with the offended dignity of a king returning from exile'. (lines 8–9)

..... [2]

- (c) (i) In paragraph 4, what does Haseeb discover when he brushes dirt from the brass star?

..... [1]

- (ii) Why does Haseeb cover Sameera's name with his shoe?

..... [1]

- (d) Explain what Abdul Hayee notices that makes Haseeb appear taller. (line 22)

..... [1]

- (e) In paragraph 6, how does Haseeb feel after he snaps at Abdul Hayee?

Give two details from the text to support your answer.

Haseeb's feeling

details

..... [3]

(f) Explain what Haseeb is thinking when he lifts the script 'as though it might bruise beneath his fingers'. (lines 40–41)

.....
 [2]

(g) From paragraph 8, give **two details** which show why Haseeb believes Sameera deserved greater recognition.

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- [2]

(h) **Explain using your own words** Abdul Hayee's different feelings during the visit to the theatre. **Give three details** from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

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 [3]
[Total: 16]

Question 2

- (a) Read this extract from the text:

"The auditorium opened below us. Hundreds of seats rose in curved rows, their folded cushions resembling dark mouths. On stage, the main curtain hung in heavy red folds, grey with dust. Haseeb descended the aisle slowly, but when his shoes touched the boards, his back straightened. He looked taller." (lines 19–22)

What **two impressions** does the writer want to convey about the theatre and Haseeb in this extract?

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..... [2]

- (b) Read this sentence from the text:

"For several seconds the largest lever resisted us like a rusted bone." (line 28)

What effect does the writer suggest about the lever by using the phrase 'resisted us like a rusted bone' to describe it?

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..... [2]

- (c) Explain why the writer uses the word 'spilled' rather than 'shone' in the sentence 'a single spotlight spilled onto the stage like a pale coin'. (lines 29–30)

.....

..... [1]

- (d) Read this extract from the text:

"Then his face softened. 'Though not always steadily,' he added, producing a smile that could not disguise his embarrassment." (lines 34–36)

What does the writer want to suggest to the reader about Haseeb's feelings at this point in the story?

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..... [1]

(e) Identify **one example** from the text below of how the writer uses language effectively to convey Abdul Hayee's changed view of the theatre at the end of the visit.

"Before we left, he placed the script inside a dry archive case for the city museum. At the side door, he handed me the theatre key. It felt unexpectedly warm from his palm. 'They will need this tomorrow,' I said. 'Eventually,' he replied. I carried it down the steps, and he did not ask for it back. Behind us, the damaged sign caught the headlights of a passing car and blazed briefly above the entrance - not restored, not performing, but still capable of an encore." (lines 69–74)

Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified.

example

explanation

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..... [3]

[Total: 9]